

ANI

'EVERYONE IS WELCOME' Ex-CM Harish Rawat backs the new unity

The bad blood dates back to March 2016, when Harak led a nine-MLA renegade band to the BJP, bringing down the Harish Rawat regime. In 2022, a tearful Harak returned, after being expelled by the BJP for "indiscipline". Homecoming rites were low-key. Harish came, but was visibly grouchy.

HISS AND MAKE UP

The rivalry soon resurfaced. As recently as June, the two Rawats were still trading barbs over 2016 and the party's electoral slump thereafter. The Grand Old Party won only 19 seats in the 2022 state polls—the BJP took 47 seats in the 70-seat assembly. It went on to seal that dominance in 2024, when it swept all five Lok Sabha seats in the state.

Cut to now, and Harish finds himself sharing social media posts backing "Dr Harak". "I am only working to remove the sinful BJP from power. Everyone is welcome to achieve this goal," he wrote recently.

The focus now is to give the cadre a new centrality. "In the BJP, leaders like Advani could be sidelined because of a strong cadre. But we were too dependent on our leaders. That's changing," says a party elder. State Congress chief Karan Mahara says things are "95 per cent" fine and "morale is up". As proof of a turnaround, he cites the recent panchayat poll. Though not fought strictly on party lines, the Congress claimed "138 victories", versus BJP's "127". Right now, even a contested claim of revival counts as a plus. ■

Takeaways

- **Satraps bury the hatchet, new focus on cadre. Result: good outing in local polls**
- **Script for revival written in Delhi. In June, party brass Kharge and Rahul read the riot act to the rival Rawats, Harish and Harak, others**

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

FOR A DEITY KNOWN AS THE LORD OF THE UNIVERSE, his legions of devotees seem to be struggling with a very earthly problem: scheduling. To be more accurate, narrow that down to the priestly class in charge of his day care and boarding. When exactly should the mighty Jagannath be bathed, wheeled out of his sanctum for his rath yatra, and be brought back home? These seemingly mundane questions have two sets of ecclesiastes trading unholy blows.

On one side stand the traditional custodians ensconced in the Shree Jagannatha Temple Administration (SJTA) of Puri, armed with scriptures, hallowed *tithi* calendars, and the weight of centuries-old ritual authority. On September 6, a press release from them addressed the other side—the International Society for Krishna Consciousness (ISKCON)—with all the holy rage of a pontiff taking on a newfangled, wayward pretender. It accused the global spiritual organisation of "violating sacred scriptures and tradition" by merrily carting the Lord around on dates of their own convenience.

JUGGERNAUT OF QUERIES

For good measure, it reiterated that non-negotiable tradition: the bathing-related *snana yatra*, commemorating Jagannath's "birthday", on Jyestha Poornima; the rath yatra commencing

"ISKCON is committing the blunder of conducting sacred rituals of Lord Jagannath on random dates for 50 years... violating the scriptures (with) weird arguments"

GAJAPATI DIBYASINGHA DEB
Puri maharaja & chief administrator